

Lab: The Language of Fiber and Color

Materials Exploration — Communication

Objective

Explore the communicative systems of the fiber arts by testing how well yarn labels, color classifications, and texture descriptions transmit information. You will discover the strengths and limits of craft communication.

Materials Needed

- 5-6 yarn samples with labels (varying fiber content, weight, and color)
- A color wheel (printed or digital)
- Paper and colored pencils
- A notebook for observations
- A friend or fellow crafter (recommended)

Part 1: Decoding the Label (15 minutes)

1. For each yarn sample, read only the label (do not touch the yarn yet).
2. Based solely on the label information, write predictions:
3. How will this yarn feel?
4. What stitch definition will it produce?
5. What projects would it be suitable for?
6. Now touch and examine each yarn. How accurate were your label-based predictions?

Reflection: The label is a compressed communication. How much predictive power does it have? What important information is missing from the label?

Part 2: Color Communication Challenge (20 minutes)

1. Choose 3 yarns and design a simple color palette (3 colors that work together).

2. Write a description of your palette using color theory vocabulary (warm, cool, analogous, complementary, high contrast, low contrast).
3. Give only the written description to a partner (no showing the yarn).
4. Have your partner select 3 yarns that match your description.
5. Compare: Did your partner select similar colors? Where did communication succeed or fail?

Reflection: Color description is a test of shared generative models. How well did your vocabulary transmit your visual intentions?

Part 3: Texture Telephone (15 minutes)

1. Without showing a yarn sample, describe its texture to a partner using only words: "fuzzy," "smooth," "bumpy," "crisp," "drapey," "stiff," etc.
2. Have your partner attempt to select a similar-textured yarn from the samples.
3. Switch roles and repeat.

Reflection: Texture is notoriously hard to communicate verbally. What vocabulary was most effective? What aspects of texture resisted verbal description?

Part 4: Pattern Clarity Test (15 minutes)

1. Write a simple set of crochet instructions for a 10-stitch, 5-row swatch in a basic stitch pattern.
2. Give your instructions (without any other context) to a partner.
3. Have them attempt to follow your instructions.
4. Compare the two swatches. Do they match?

Reflection: Pattern writing is model transmission. How clear was your communication? Where did ambiguity creep in?

Discussion Questions

1. Which communication system worked best — labels, color descriptions, texture words, or pattern instructions?
2. What information about yarn is hardest to communicate without physical contact?

3. How do shared standards (weight categories, color names) help or hinder communication?

Reflection

Write a short paragraph about the languages of the fiber arts. How do we communicate about materials, colors, and techniques? What works well, and what remains stubbornly hard to put into words?